

ISTQB FOUNDATION MASTERCLASS

Memory Aids & Mnemonics

Simple, correct mnemonics for the lists the ISTQB exam loves to test.

Why Mnemonics Work

The Foundation exam is full of ordered and unordered lists — the seven testing principles, the test levels, the fundamental test process, the review roles. A short, memorable phrase turns a list you would forget under pressure into one you can rebuild letter by letter.

The Seven Testing Principles — "SEE-D-CAP"

Recall the seven principles with the phrase "SEE-D-CAP".

Letter	Stands for	Principle
S	Shows presence	Testing shows the presence of defects, not their absence.
E	Exhaustive impossible	Exhaustive testing is impossible.
E	Early testing	Early testing saves time and money (shift-left).
D	Defects cluster	Defects cluster together (Pareto).
C	no Cure-all (pesticide)	Tests wear out — the pesticide paradox; vary your tests.
A	context-dependent (Adapt)	Testing is context dependent.
P	Presence != correct (absence-of-errors)	The absence-of-errors fallacy — a bug-free system can still fail user needs.

Test Levels — "Can I See Accurately?"

The four test levels, in order from smallest to largest scope: Can (Component) I (Integration) See (System) Accurately (Acceptance).

- C — Component (unit) testing
- I — Integration testing
- S — System testing
- A — Acceptance testing

Fundamental Test Process — "Please Make Delicious Iced Coffee, Cheers"

The test activities in the ISTQB test process spell PMDICC.

Letter	Activity
P — Please	Planning
M — Make	Monitoring and control
D — Delicious	Design (analysis and design)
I — Iced	Implementation
C — Coffee	Execution (Carry out the tests)
C — Cheers	Completion (Closure)

Review Roles — "MAM-SR"

The key roles in a formal review: MAM-SR.

- M — Manager (decides on the review, allocates resources)
- A — Author (creator of the work product under review)
- M — Moderator / Facilitator (leads the meeting, keeps it objective)
- S — Scribe / Recorder (documents the findings)
- R — Reviewer (examines the work product; the Review Leader takes overall responsibility)

Review Types by Formality — "I Won't Take It" (least to most formal)

1. I — Informal review (least formal)
2. W — Walkthrough
3. T — Technical review
4. I — Inspection (most formal)

Black-box Techniques — "Every Boundary Deserves Structure"

- E — Equivalence Partitioning
- B — Boundary Value Analysis
- D — Decision Table testing
- S — State transition testing (plus use case testing)

A Good Defect Report — "SES-RE"

- S — Summary (clear, unique title and ID)
- E — Environment and preconditions
- S — Steps to reproduce
- R — Result: expected vs actual
- E — Evaluation: severity, priority and status

BEST PRACTICE

Write each mnemonic once from memory, then rebuild the full list it stands for. If you can expand every letter into the correct term, the list is exam-ready.

COMMON MISTAKE

Do not confuse "priority" and "severity", or "verification" and "validation". Verification = building it right (to spec); Validation = building the right thing (to user needs).